PHOTOGRAPH BY MAX BROSI

Max Brosi in profile

We meet Irish woodturner **Max Brosi**, who creates unusual sculptural woodturnings

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Max spent his childhood outdoors, in the woods and by the coast in North West Ireland, exploring cliffs, collecting driftwood and beach-combing. Whenever he wasn't getting into trouble, Max was making things with wood. To Max it was play, but when he looks back now he can see it was the beginning of a lifelong education in the properties and applications of natural materials. By carving catapults, bows and arrows and other things with his grandfather's penknife, Max was subconsciously learning which way wood cut cleanly and which way fibres tore out, which wood is easy to work and how not to cut himself, etc.

For Max's 8th birthday he was given an electric jigsaw, but before he was allowed use it, he was taken to a local joinery where his mother asked to see the head joiner, who she knew. The purpose was to show Max the joiners' two hands… "which collectively had roughly as many digits as one hand should," Max tells us. "Point made!"

Through his secondary school years there were two areas that held Max's imagination, working with wood and being in the sea in any way he could. After school, Max was fortunate enough to be accepted to The Furniture College in Letterfrack, a mecca for those interested in design and working with wood, nestled between the mountains and the sea in Connemara.

"For the next decade or more life swung like a pendulum between designing and making furniture and taking time out to go on foreign surf trips, learn sailing and become a scuba diving instructor," Max explained. In 2007, Max started a small business designing and building hollow wooden surfboards. "This was great," Max explains. "I was my own boss and I was able to combine my interests of wood and salt water." However, soon after the recession in Ireland kicked in, Max was back in college earning a Higher Diploma in Education. He was a woodwork teacher now and landed a job running a Furniture Design course in Cavan Institute, a Further Education College. Max was asked to teach marquetry, furniture making, materials and finishes and woodturning. While completing the Higher Diploma and working as a teacher, Max was finally able to realise a lifelong dream, to build himself and his wife a wooden house, calling it 'our base and our home'.

Getting into woodturning

While at college in 2004, Max needed to earn some extra money. He examined his skill set and decided to stick with woodworking, so he bought a cheap lathe with the intention of producing three legged stools with clean Scandinavian lines. He thought, 'it couldn't be too hard? I'm a trained furniture maker after all' and 'surely the world would queue up for these?' Unfortunately, that didn't happen and the lathe was briefly revisited every other month, to turn a furniture component or two… "Rather badly!" Max admits. With having no formal instruction in woodturning, not even a book on the subject, Max had just a few hours of precariously stabbing at a spinning piece of spruce with a blunt chisel in secondary school.

Yet, as time passed Max was exposed to the work of Liam Flynn and Ernst Gamperl and he thought 'they did that! On a lathe?!' His eyes had been opened. The years Max spent as a child exploring material and shape in rocks and driftwood, sea glass and rusty iron came back to him, ideas for forms, vessels and sculptures emerged. Yet, he was in need of learning the technical skills of woodturning, so bought a book on turning (*Woodturning: A Foundation Course* by Keith Rowley) and began teaching himself from this. Once again, something clicked for Max, quickly realising turning a bowl was something that felt good and very natural. "It was a vessel," Max explains. "Like a house, like a wooden boat and vessel making is something very primeval and natural to us as humans."

Fast forward eight or so years and Max is a teacher, who was asked to teach students

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